Though Honecker seemed confident and self-assured when Schmidt postponed their meeting, he was deeply vexed at the snub and responded by issuing a slew of measures restricting human and political contact between the two Germanys. As the situation changed from day to day, the flow of Western visitors to the East was reduced, currency regulations tightened, and new controls were imposed on cultural visits and church relations.

Although foreign affairs offered some escape from the troublesome Polish problems, Honecker's pent-up anger was unleashed during his first state visit to Austria in November, where he angrily reported to his host, Chancellor Bruno Kreisky, that Helmut Schmidt had not even considered it necessary to have a minister or at least a State Secretary deliver the bad news about cancelling their meeting but had used the telephone. The intense disrespect, according to a Viennese diplomat, 'really hurt him'.8

Despite a few dissenting voices, the Austrian press was unfailingly polite about Honecker's visit. Only a commentary in the daily Vienna Kurier by analyst Heinz Nussbaumer raised eyebrows. In his 300-word assessment, Nussbaumer questioned whether in the 'present crisis of détente' it was expedient for Honecker, 'a man who could hardly deny his share of responsibility for the development of that crisis', to be greeted with all protocol honours. The author cited two of Honecker's reactions to the Poland crisis. Firstly, the raising of the compulsory Deutsche Mark conversion quota for West German visitors and, secondly, his decision to impose visas on Poles.9

As it happened, the trip to Vienna paid dividends. The East Germans secured huge loans along with an Austrian promise to bankroll the development of a new steelworks in Eisenhüttenstadt, a town in the Oder-Spree district of Brandenburg (these loans made a decisive contribution in keeping the GDR economy afloat during the early 1980s).10 In other ways, too, Honecker was triumphant. During his talks with Kreisky, he touted the prospect of cultural exchanges between the two countries and even held out the possibility of improved tourism for youngsters and teenagers.

After Vienna, Honecker resumed his gaze upon Warsaw by cordoning off the possibility of contagion with a new set of travel restrictions. On 4 November, Brezhnev wrote to Honecker explaining it was essential to